

In the [next-intl](#) library for Next.js, the `NEXT_LOCALE` cookie is a standard mechanism used to persist a user's language preference. 

Core Functionality

- **Persistence:** When a user manually selects a language, `next-intl` (or your custom language switcher) can set the `NEXT_LOCALE` cookie to store this choice.
- **Priority:** On subsequent visits, Next.js and `next-intl` prioritize this cookie value over the browser's `Accept-Language` header.
- **Middleware Integration:** The [middleware](#) provided by `next-intl` reads this cookie to determine the appropriate locale for redirects and content rendering. 

Common Usage Patterns

- **With Locale-based Routing:** The cookie helps the [router](#) redirect users from the root path (`/`) to their preferred locale-prefixed path (e.g., `/en` or `/fr`).
- **Without Locale-based Routing:** If you do not use locale prefixes in your URLs, the cookie becomes the primary source of truth for the active locale.
- **Manual Updates:** You can manually update this cookie using standard client-side methods like `document.cookie` or server-side via [Next.js Cookies API](#) to trigger a language switch. 

Configuration & Security

- **Custom Cookie Name:** While the default is `NEXT_LOCALE` , some configurations allow for [custom cookie names](#).
- **Opting Out:** Setting `localeDetection: false` in your middleware configuration can disable the automatic setting of this cookie.
- **Security Note:** By default, this cookie may be accessible via JavaScript (non- `HttpOnly`), which is often necessary for client-side language switching but should be considered in your [security model](#).